MALL JINKS



Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

SUHELDEV BHARATIYA SAMAJ PARTY

Om Prakash Rajbhar, President

Om Prakash Rajbhar, UP's panchayati raj minister and expert political weather forecaster, is one of those who gets away with free speech on even saffron icons. Now, he's on the prowl again, having recently met CM Yogi Adityanath to demand a quota within the OBC quota for the Rajbhars.

If that gives the heebie-jeebies to the BJP, history explains it. The SBSP, formed in 2002, draws on the Rajbhar footprint in Purvanchal. Its damage potential showed in 2022: with the SP, it contested 19 seats, won six, and hurt the BJP in 33. The lotus failed to bloom in Ghazipur (seven seats), Azamgarh (10), won only one of four in Mau, one of seven in Ballia, two of nine in Jaunpur.

Rajbhar was urgently wooed back into the NDA in 2023—restoring the status of 2017, when the SBSP was an ally and he served briefly in the Yogi cabinet. But it was like inviting a thorn back into the flesh. Now, Rajbhar wants his pound of it—and more.

"Only a few dominant OBC castes are reaping quota benefits. Most backward and extremely backward communities remain excluded"

APNA DAL (SONELAL)

Ashish Patel, ex-Working President

Perhaps the BJP's most crucial ally in UP, the AD(S) seems profoundly cheesed off with big brother. Tensions arose in July, after Brajendra Patel and other founding members split to form 'Apna Morcha', claiming the support of nine of the party's 13 MLAs. The main party, led by Union minister Anupriya Patel, calls them oustees, expelled in 2022 for anti-party activities. Yet, the new front says it will contest the upcoming panchayat polls while, surprise, still backing the NDA. So, who's in?

Anupriya's husband Ashish Patel, who has stepped down as party working president, is threatening to quit the UP cabinet itself. He questions the BJP's intentions, suggesting the rebels are being encouraged to fragment the AD(S) base. Fragmentation is wired into the Apna Dal story—the AD(S) is only the biggest splinter of the original party founded by the late Sone Lal Patel in 1995, with a solid Kurmi base in around 20 districts of eastern and central UP. Anupriya's faction has been with the BJP since 2014, while the rival faction led by mother Krishna and sister Pallavi aligned with the SP.

"They show daily that the AD(S) is falling apart. Don't go through this hassle. Today, once and for all, break it into as many parts as you want"



Anupriya and Ashish Patel

Pallavi even defeated current deputy CM Keshav Maurya in the 2022 election on an SP ticket. But again, she's also said to be close to CM Yogi Adityanath, a link that blurs party lines further and keeps everyone guessing.

To map the AD(S)'s restiveness, contrast it with the quietude of the RLD, which rejoined the NDA in 2024. That its latest ally seems the most solid suffices to describe the BJP's state in UP.